

HIGH SCHOOL BOYS BASKETBALL

DIVISION I

Bulldogs' Braddick steps up to bounce St. Ed

BOB MIGRA
Plain Dealer Reporter

OLMSTED FALLS	67	fourth quar-
ST. EDWARD	58	ter. His final

basket gave

Olmsted Falls a 59-54 lead with 1:40 left.

Pat Braddick could not have picked a better night to have a career game.

The junior forward from Olmsted Falls scored 23 points to lead the second-seeded Bulldogs to a 67-58 victory over No. 1 seed St. Edward in the boys basketball Division I district championship in front of a sellout crowd of 1,750 at Midview on Saturday.

Braddick capped his night by scoring six consecutive points in what had been a back-and-forth

"It feels unbelievable," Braddick said, before taking his turn cutting down the nets. "It's not my role to do the scoring, but they gave me open looks and my teammates kept getting me the ball."

Braddick's previous high was 18 points. His outburst was especially timely because Olmsted Falls' leading scorer, Steve Gansey, got in foul trouble early and

was limited to 15 points. Gansey scored a combined 63 points in the Bulldogs' two previous tournament victories.

"Braddick had an outstanding game," Olmsted Falls coach Pat Donahue said. "Pat's one of those guys that if you ignore him, he'll hurt you."

Braddick really hurt St. Edward in the third quarter, when he scored 10 points, including a 3-point goal with 1:47 left for a 47-40 Olmsted Falls lead.

After five lead changes in the fourth quarter, Braddick gave the Bulldogs breathing room with a

driving layup, two foul shots, and another layup off a nice touch-pass from Jamar Scales.

The Bulldogs then hit 8 of 11 foul shots down the stretch to pull away.

Olmsted Falls (21-2) advances to next week's regional tournament at the University of Toledo. St. Edward finishes at 19-4.

"One of the things that people don't realize about Olmsted Falls is that their role players are pretty good," St. Edward coach Eric Flannery said. "We obviously put a lot of focus on their main guys, but their other play-

ers stepped up and hurt us."

Dan Binggeli scored 12 points and Scales broke out of a slump on the Midview court with nine points, eight rebounds, four assists and two blocked shots.

Chris Moore, a 6-9 senior, led the Eagles with 17 points and 11 rebounds, but Flannery said he wanted to get the ball into Moore a lot more.

"We did a terrible job of getting the ball inside," Flannery said. "At halftime, we stressed getting the ball inside. At every timeout, we stressed getting the ball inside, but it's easier said

than done."

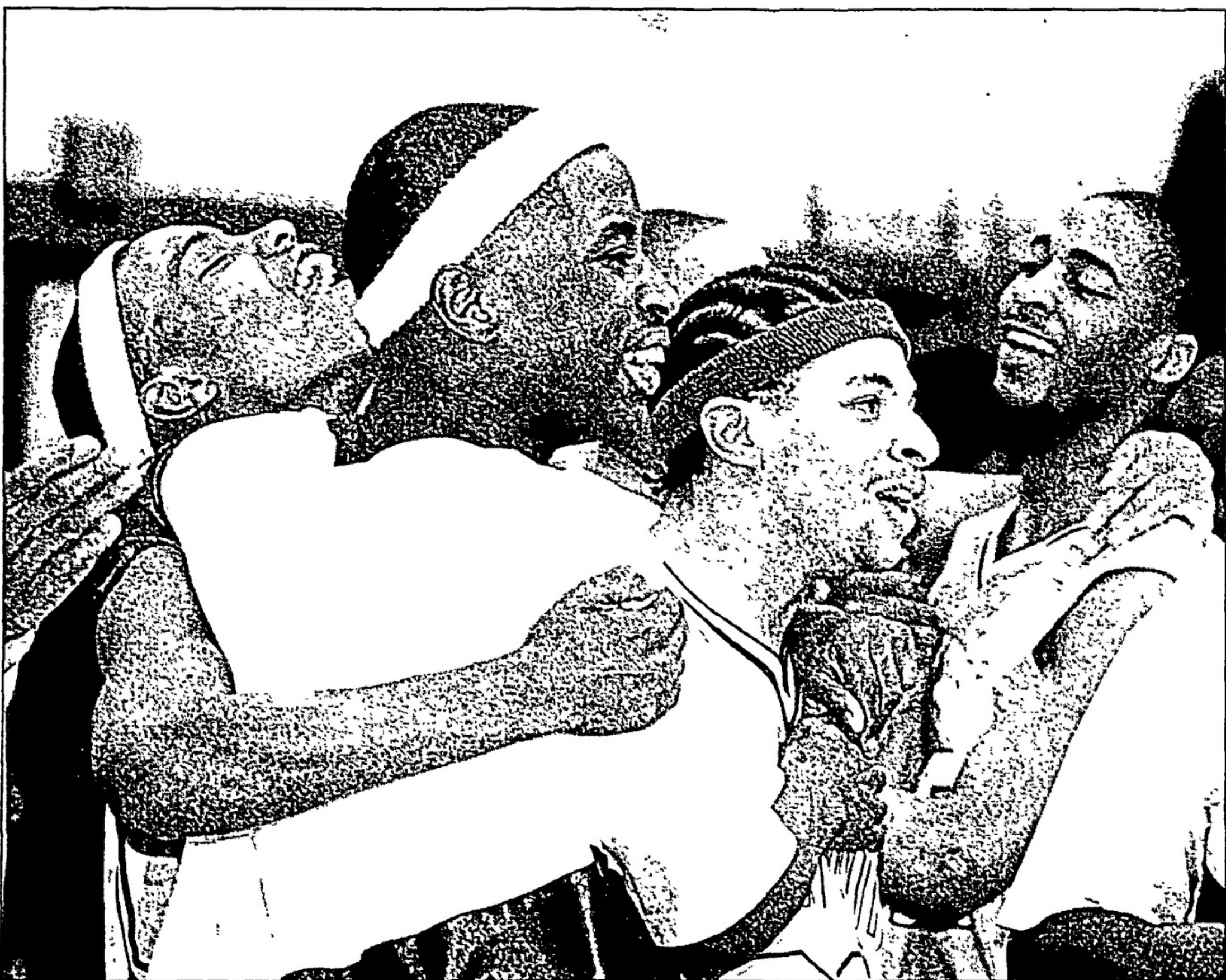
Ryan Marando had 14 points and eight rebounds for St. Edward. Marando hit a 3-point goal, a driving layup and a foul-line jump shot in succession to cut the Bulldogs lead to 47-44 after three quarters.

Braddick said he didn't consider the victory an upset.

"Absolutely not," he said. "We came into this game feeling like we could beat these guys, and we proved it."

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DIVISION I



The Railroaders can let loose as they realize they have locked up a Division I district title with their win Saturday against Glenville in Euclid.

Jeremy's spoken

Weaver's shot lifts Railroaders

EDDIE DWYER
Plain Dealer Reporter

COLLINWOOD	55	quickest team in
GLENVILLE	54	the area.

But, as Railroaders standout senior forward Jeremy Weaver said, his team's success is all about defense and second-effort.

And no one made a bigger effort Saturday night than Weaver.

Collinwood, on the strength of Weaver's rebound and putback at the final buzzer, turned back a young and talented Glenville team, 55-54, in a Division I boys basketball district championship game at Euclid's Harold "Doc" Daugherty Gymnasium.

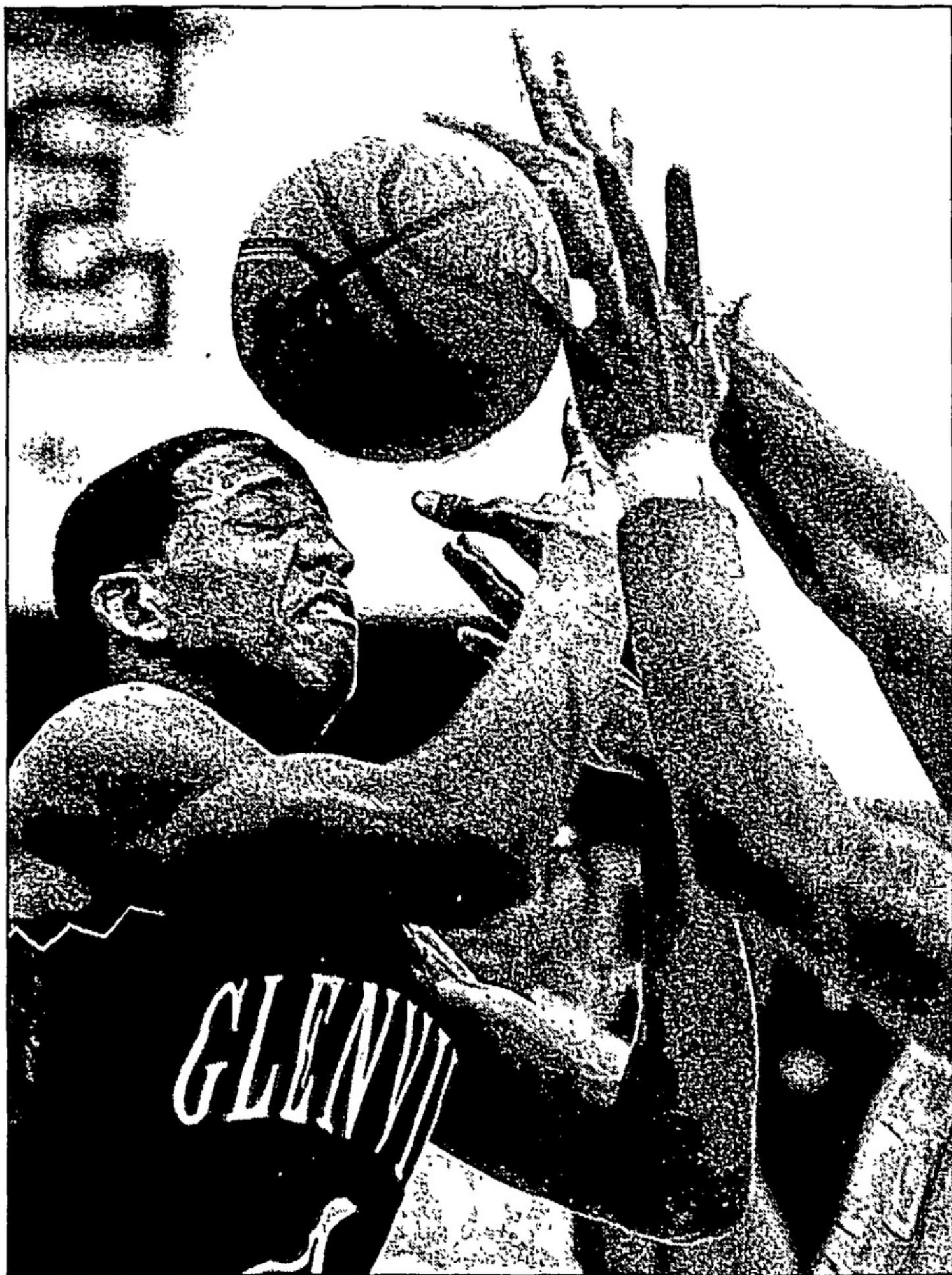
The Railroaders, under the direction of veteran coach Ken Vana, will take a 20-3 record into Thursday's 7 p.m. regional semifinal at the University of Akron's JAR Arena. Their opponent is the Bedford Bearcats (14-9), who defeated Cleveland Heights, 70-60, in Saturday's district final at Cleveland South.

"I thought, as a whole, we played one of our poorer games of the year in regard to shot selection, rebounding and turning the ball over," Vana said after his team defeated its Senate Athletic League rival for the third time this season. "Anybody that saw this game realizes we were fortunate to win it. It's a real shame somebody had to lose this ballgame, and I really mean that. Both teams left it out on the floor."

Collinwood, which joins another Cleveland public school team, the Rhodes Rams, in Sweet 16 play, moved to a 29-18 lead midway through the second quarter. But Glenville, which closed its season at 15-8, got two 3-pointers from All-Senate junior guard Kenny McCornell and closed to 29-24 by halftime.

Continuing to hold the hot hand, the Tarblooders, behind a leaning one-hander off glass by McCornell, a putback by senior forward Brandon Williams and a soft jumper 6-7 sophomore Justin Dobbins, took a 35-33 lead with 2:16 left in the third quarter.

Weaver would answer with consecutive 3-pointers but, after a McCornell



Glenville's Brandon Morris can't quite get his hands wrapped around a rebound during Saturday night's loss to Collinwood.

jump shot and a follow by junior forward Curtis Smith, the score was knotted at 39 entering the final eight minutes.

McCornell, who gives Tarblooders coach Michael Holt a spark off the bench, put his team in front, 52-50, by hitting a driving one-hander down the lane with 49 seconds remaining.

Railroaders senior guard Stacy Sorrell, who was playing with four fouls, buried a 3-pointer from the right corner that made the score 53-52 with 36 seconds to go.

But after Collinwood failed to increase its one-point lead from the foul line, Glenville junior guard Leon Ward

snank two free throws that put the Tarblooders back in front, 54-53, with 11.2 seconds to go.

"Everybody in the gym probably thought 'ballgame' [at that point]," said Vana, who coached the Railroaders to a school-best 22 victories in the 1995-96 season. "But isn't it ironic? We don't rebound all night, but we rebound the miss for the game-winner."

That rebound saw Weaver hustle after a missed jump shot by Sorrell and power the ball up along the left baseline a second before time expired.

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DIVISION I

Medina thrilling in overtime title win

TIM ROGERS
Plain Dealer Reporter

MEDINA	59	range jumpers and
WADSWORTH	56	9 of 10 free throws.

His second 3-pointer of the game opened the second overtime and gave Medina a lead it never relinquished.

Dann Bruno said his Medina teammates had battled too long and too hard and all he wanted to do was give them what they deserved.

In one of the most dramatic games the Medina Countians have seen in some time, unheralded Medina continued its magical postseason run on Saturday when it slipped past Wadsworth, 59-56, in double overtime to win a Division I district championship in front of 3,056 fans at Copley High.

Bruno's two free throws with 30.8 seconds remaining in the second overtime snapped a 56-56 tie and junior Donta Anthony added one more with 12.6 seconds left as the Bees (16-8) won the school's first district championship since the 1999-2000 season.

Medina, which entered the sectional as an unseeded team, will play Canton McKinley in a regional semifinal game on Wednesday at 7 p.m. in James A. Rhodes Arena. McKinley defeated Austintown Fitch in the finals of the Canton district.

Medina can celebrate the third district championship in school history and no one can say the Bees didn't earn it. They defeated top-seeded Wooster, third-seeded Stow and second-seeded Wadsworth in their three tournament games to become the 10th different champion the tournament has crowned since it returned to Copley 10 years ago.

"It is just unbelievable," said Medina coach Jody Peters, a Medina graduate. "I'm speechless. Right now, the feeling of joy and exhilaration I feel for our kids and what they have done together — and that's the important part — is phenomenal."

Anthony, a 5-10 guard, was magnificent as he led everyone with 29 points on a variety of acrobatic layups, short-

range jumpers and 9 of 10 free throws. His second 3-pointer of the game opened the second overtime and gave Medina a lead it never relinquished.

Anthony had plenty of support as Bruno and fellow senior Andy Glass contributed 11 and 12 points, respectively. None, perhaps, were bigger than Bruno's two free throws at the end.

"Our guys battled all night to keep it close and I didn't want to let them down," said Bruno, a 6-1 guard. "I just pretended like it was practice and knocked them down. I tried to be as relaxed as possible. We have struggled off and on all year, but this is the reward."

The Bees struggled with off-the-court problems that resulted in two players being suspended.

As expected, the loss was a bitter one for Wadsworth, ranked 10th in the state and 13th in The Plain Dealer Top 25. The Grizzlies (20-3) had methodically defeated Suburban League rival Green in Thursday's semifinals after guard Ben Falkenberg had helped eliminate Hudson when he scored 46 points in the sectional finals.

Falkenberg was held to 15 points.

"Ben is a great player," Peters praised. "He makes them go. We did a great job of defending him. We made him work for every point he got. I don't think he ever got into any kind of rhythm."

Falkenberg's running mate, senior Paul Macko, finished with 13 points and almost won the game for the Grizzlies when he tossed in three straight 3-point shots in the fourth quarter when the Grizzlies rallied from a 41-35 deficit to take a 49-47 lead with 45 seconds left.

Anthony forced overtime with a pair of free throws with 20 seconds left.

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DIVISION II

Swift work helps Tigers stop Warriors' season

TIM WARSINSKEY
Plain Dealer Reporter

WARRENSVILLE HTS.	69	they had a lot to do
FAIRVIEW	49	with it."

Warrensville Heights' run of district titles began with Brian Swift on the court, and it continued with him in the stands and his heir, Korey Spates, creating much of the same magic Saturday.

Warrensville Heights won its fourth district championship in five years with a 69-49 thrashing of Fairview in a Division II final at Solon High School.

The Tigers (11-12) head to the Canton regional on Friday to play Canal Fulton Northwest (22-1).

Spates scored 29 points, and the Tigers held Fairview standout Brendan Schuler to 12 points on 4-of-12 shooting thanks largely to a defensive scheme that Swift helped implement in practice.

Swift, a 2001 Warrensville grad who plays at the University of South Florida, came home this week and helped teach the Tigers how to break down the pick-and-roll and back-door cuts that Fairview and Schuler thrived off of this season.

"Brian Swift showed us how Brendan Schuler would be coming off screens and that helped us out a lot," said Tigers senior Pier Sharp, who guarded Schuler. "Schuler's a tough kid, and he played his heart out. I gave him all I could give him."

Schuler helped lead Fairview (14-10) to its first district final, but he and the Warriors were thrown off their rhythm by Warrensville's pressure defense and surprisingly slow pace on offense.

"I thought they would try to push the tempo on us," Fairview coach Eric Smith said. "When we got down, it was trouble. There was no comfort zone for us. We never got into an offensive flow, and

ran deep. Schuler missed all eight of his 3-point attempts and fouled out. He received his second technical foul on the way to the bench. Fairview's bench also received a technical, which resulted in Spates sinking six straight free throws with 16 seconds remaining.

Warrensville Heights also controlled the boards. Forwards Robert Mercer and Chris Jones combined to score just eight points, but they had 24 rebounds.

"That was one of my biggest concerns — their athleticism on the boards," Smith said. "They just wore us down."

Spates controlled everything else, hitting big shots and setting up his teammates every time Fairview attempted to make a run in the second half. Spates was 8-of-15 from the field, 11-of-11 at the line and had five assists, four steals and two blocked shots.

"He's a phenomenal player," Warrensville coach Dennis Chimes said. "I had Brian Swift, and I would say Korey is going to be just like Brian, maybe even a little bit better."

Spates scored 15 in the first half as the Tigers took a 26-24 lead. Warrensville Heights sat on a 22-20 lead for two minutes, stalling while going unchallenged. When the Tigers moved the ball, Schuler stole it and Ryan Rozak scored two of his 14 to tie it. Spates countered on offense with a four-point play.

Warrensville committed eight turnovers in the third quarter, but outscored Fairview, 14-6, as the Warriors missed 13 of 16 shots. They also missed their first seven shots of the fourth quarter.

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